

The Philosophy of Alchemical Thaumaturgy: The Science of Essence

In the *Ætherium Codex*, alchemy is not a distinct form of magic. It is a highly specialized application of Artifice and Medicine. An alchemist is an artisan who works not with wood and steel, but with the raw Archetypal Properties found in creature components, planar flora, and magically saturated minerals. Their goal is to isolate, concentrate, and recombine these properties to create substances with predictable, potent effects.

The Alchemical "Sentence": Designing a Substance

Just as a mage composes a spell, an alchemist designs a formula. Every alchemical creation follows a fundamental structure:

- * The Alchemical Effect (The Verb): What is the substance's primary function? This is the core of the alchemist's intent.
 - * Infuse: Deliberately introduces Planar Strain of a specific type. Used to create mutagens.
 - * Purge: Actively removes Planar Strain from a subject. Used to create antidotes and purifiers.
 - * Stabilize: Prevents the "calcification" of Strain into a permanent Score, or temporarily suppresses a negative mutation.
 - * Catalyze: Acts as a catalyst during a magical process, such as an Item Ascension ritual, potentially guiding the outcome.
 - * Ward: Provides a temporary, targeted bonus to resist gaining Strain from a specific planar source.
- * The Planar Essence (The Noun): Which planar energy is being manipulated? The alchemist must use components rich in a specific Archetype.
 - * To create a mutagen that inflicts fire-based mutations, one must use components with the [Flame] Archetype.
 - * To create a purifier that removes chaotic Borderlands Frost energies, one might use a stabilizing agent with the [Borderlands: Fire] Archetype.
- * The Reagents (The Modifiers): How is the substance's effect altered? These are additional ingredients that add complexity.
 - * Potency: Increases the "dose" of the effect (more Strain inflicted/purged, higher resistance bonus).

- * Duration: Makes the effect last longer.
- * Toxicity: Adds a negative side-effect (a "detriment"), but often makes the substance easier or cheaper to create.
- * Inertia: A slow-acting agent; the effect is delayed but may be more potent or harder to detect.
- * The Vector (The Delivery System): How is the substance applied?
- * Potion/Ingestible: Must be consumed.
- * Salve/Topical: Must be applied to the skin.
- * Inoculation: Must be injected, often bypassing natural resistances.
- * Aerosol/Gas: Affects an area.

The Alchemy Mini-Game: The Process of Creation

This is the interactive system for actually making the substance. It adapts the "Artifice Engine" we designed for crafting, but uses the Medicine skill, as it requires knowledge of biology and esoteric anatomy.

- * The Formula & Components: The alchemist must first possess the formula and gather the necessary components, each with its own Archetypes, Quality, and Volatility.
- * The Brewing Cycle: The alchemist begins the process, which requires a number of "brewing sessions" (equivalent to the "work weeks" for smithing). The number of successful sessions required is based on the complexity of the formula.
- * The Medicine Check & Degrees of Success: In each session, the alchemist makes a Medicine check. The outcome is determined by the Degrees of Success.

| Check Result vs. DC | Event | Outcome |

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| +10 or higher | Breakthrough! | The substance is created with a purely beneficial, unexpected mutation (e.g., longer shelf-life, a pleasant side-effect, increased potency). The alchemist may even discover an improvement to the base formula. |

| +0 to +9 | Stable Reaction | The substance is created exactly as the formula dictates. Standard success. |

| -1 to -4 | Volatile Reaction | The substance is created, but it gains a minor negative quirk (e.g., a foul taste, a minor but harmless side-effect like turning the user's skin blue for an hour). |

| -5 to -9 | Inert Substance | The reaction fails. No substance is created, and the components are wasted. |

| -10 or lower | Catastrophic Reaction! | The reaction fails spectacularly. The components are destroyed, and a negative consequence occurs: a minor explosion, a cloud of toxic gas, or even the spontaneous creation of a low-tier Ooze monster born from the unstable materials.

Stress Test in Action: Crafting a "Stabilizing Salve"

Let's see how an alchemist would create a substance to help someone accidentally exposed to the Borderlands of fire.

- * Goal: Create a salve that temporarily halts the progression of "Borderlands: Fire Strain" to prevent it from becoming a permanent mutation.

- * Alchemical Sentence: Effect: Stabilize + Essence: [Borderlands: Frost] (to counter the Borderlands: Fire chaos) + Vector: Salve.

- * The Alchemist: A Tier 4 Artisan with a good Medicine skill.

- * The Process:

- * Gather Components: The alchemist sources the key ingredients: powdered silver (a material with the [Concordance] archetype) and the rendered fat of a creature known for its stability (like a basilisk).

- * Brewing: The formula requires 3 successful Medicine checks.

- * Session 1: The alchemist gets a Success with a Cost. The salve is brewing, but a Volatile Reaction occurs. The resulting substance will have a Short Shelf Life quirk; it will become inert a week after being created.

- * Session 2: A clean Success. The process continues as planned.

- * Session 3: The alchemist rolls a Critical Success! A Breakthrough occurs. They discover that adding a pinch of a specific herb not only completes the process but removes the foul smell, giving it a Soothing Aroma that grants a minor bonus to resist fear for 10 minutes after application.

- * The Final Product:

- Salve of Fleeting Stability

- * Effect: When applied, this salve prevents any accumulated Palimpsest Strain from "calcifying" into a permanent Borderlands: Fire Score for 24 hours.

- * Positive Quirk: Soothing Aroma.

- * Negative Quirk: Short Shelf Life.

This system makes alchemy a deeply engaging, risky, and creative process that is a core part of interacting with your world's most unique and dangerous feature: the constant threat of mutation.

Unified Mutation System: Strain, Escrow, and Calcification

Core Principle: All mutations begin as "unstable" burdens. They only become a permanent, alterable part of a character when the player consciously invests in them, "calcifying" the change by paying its XP cost.

Step 1: Gaining a Nascent Mutation

A Nascent Mutation is an unstable, temporary transformation that has been inflicted upon the body. There are two ways to acquire one:

- * **Involuntary Infliction (The Slow Burn):**

- * A character is exposed to a planar source and fails an Integrity save, gaining Strain.

- * When Strain from a single source exceeds the character's Integrity score, it triggers a transformation.

- * The Strain from that source resets to zero, and the character gains a Nascent Mutation thematically linked to that source.

- * **Voluntary Ascension (The Direct Approach):**

- * A character willingly uses a mutagen, performs a ritual, or subjects themselves to Ætheric Saturation.

- * They make an Integrity save against the substance's or event's Potency TN.

- * On a failure, their body is overwhelmed, and they immediately gain the intended Nascent Mutation.

Step 2: The Nascent State - A Burden in Escrow

As soon as a character gains a Nascent Mutation, two things happen immediately:

- * **The Cost is Incurred:** The mutation's full XP Cost is added to the character's XP Escrow. It now contributes to their Escrow Limit and can potentially push them into Debt.

- * **The Mutation is Unstable:** The mutation is not yet a true part of the character. This has several effects:

- * **Removable:** While in the Nascent state, the mutation can be targeted and completely removed by powerful alchemical Purge formulae or specific magical rituals. If removed, its XP Cost is cleared from the Escrow.

- * **Unreliable (Optional GM Tool):** A GM might rule that a Nascent Mutation is unreliable. For example, a Nascent claw mutation might retract inconveniently, or a Nascent mind-reading ability might flicker in and out, providing distorted information. This creates a clear and compelling choice for the player: live with the burden of the unpaid XP and the instability, or find a way to get rid of the unwanted change.

Step 3: The Player's Choice - Calcification

The player has ultimate control over the mutation's final state.

- * **The Act of Calcification:** A mutation becomes "calcified" (permanent) at the exact moment the player spends the XP to fully pay off its cost from their Escrow. This represents the character's body and soul fully accepting and integrating the change.

- * **The Consequences of Calcification:**

- * **It is Permanent:** Once calcified, the mutation can no longer be removed by any means short of a world-altering event or divine intervention. It is now a fundamental part of the character.

- * **It is Stable:** The mutation loses any unreliable quirks it had in its Nascent state. It now functions at full, predictable capacity.

- * **It is Alterable:** A calcified mutation can now be targeted by the alchemical Alter effect. While it cannot be removed, its form and function can be reshaped and refined by a skilled alchemist, allowing a player to "guide" their mutations after they've committed to them.

System Summary: The Life Cycle of a Mutation

- * **Infliction:** Gain a Nascent Mutation (via Strain or Mutagen).

- * **Escrow:** The Mutation's XP Cost is added to your Escrow.

- * **Player Choice:**

- * **Option A:** Purge it. While it's Nascent, use alchemy to remove the mutation and clear the XP cost.

- * **Option B:** Keep it. Live with the unstable mutation and its cost in your Escrow.

- * **Option C:** Master it. Pay the XP cost.

The mutation is now Calcified—permanent, stable, and ready to be customized with further alchemy.

When a player has purchased off the debt of a mutation they keep the mutation and can no longer affect it with alchemical substances to alter or change it. Magic can still alter the individual even permanently removable by magic. This is to still allow options without being too restrictive or punitive.